
ACTOR PART BOOK

The Father

the brain of the family

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

163 SPEECHES · 4631 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

WHO THE FATHER IS

Around fifty, heavy in body, pale-faced, with sharp blue eyes that go sharper the moment he is interrupted. The play's philosophical voice — a man arguing for his life by way of long speeches, always slightly ashamed afterwards of how much of himself he has had to admit. He must believe, in real time, every paradox he speaks. Not a lecturer; a man fighting to be allowed to exist as more than the worst hour of his life. Mellifluous when he controls the rhythm of his argument; violent the moment it breaks.

The specific reading the actor must commit to: **he is a well-educated middle-class man whose intellectual elegance is his shield against shame.** He uses words because the alternative is silence about what he actually did. His philosophy is not abstract — it is autobiographical, disguised as metaphysics. Every speech about *reality* or *conscience* is an attempt to argue himself back into being someone the room can listen to. He came in believing his case was defensible. By Act Three he has discovered that his own argument is the cell he is locked inside.

Shame should be visible on him without props doing the work. The audience reads it in the body — heat at the brow, breath shortening, the small adjustments of a man who would prefer to be elsewhere. He cannot quite hide what is happening to him, and the harder he tries to compose himself the more visible the trying becomes. He puts the composure back on when he is winning the argument; he loses it when he is not.

The arc to score: **Act One** — he arrives mellifluous, controlled, almost charming. He believes he can talk his way through this. The Step-Daughter's first exposure shakes him; he recovers; he keeps talking. **Act Two** — he must watch his shame literalised on a stage, twice. **Act Three** — the four-stage arc already scored in Part I: control → injury → attack → horror. He ends not winning his philosophy but walking into the wall of it. The same Step-Daughter who exposed him in Act One pushes him into the wall in Act Three. He never gets out of that room.

THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

What it is. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

This production. Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen.** One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

How it opens. The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

Act One

PART I *The Rehearsal*

THE FATHER DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

*He who is known as **THE FATHER** is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.*

***THE SON** (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for **THE FATHER**, supercilious and indifferent to **THE MOTHER**. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.*

PART II *The Plea*

65 SPEECHES · 2362 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... come in during rehearsals! Who are you, please? What do you want?

THE FATHER *[coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed].* Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

CUE *The Manager:* An author? What author?

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man):* We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

THE FATHER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER].* Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To MANAGER.]* unless you would be willing...

CUE *The Manager:* ... be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

CUE *The Manager:* ... We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer, voice softening on each clause].* Oh sir, you know well that life is full of infinite absurdities, which, strangely enough, do not even need to appear plausible, since they are true.

CUE *The Manager:* What the devil is he talking about?

THE FATHER. I say that reversing the ordinary process may well seem like madness: that is, to create credible situations, so that they appear true. But let me point out that if this be madness, it is the sole *raison d'être* of your profession, gentlemen. *[The ACTORS look hurt and perplexed.]*

CUE *The Manager:* So our profession seems to you one worthy of madmen then?

THE FATHER. Well — to make seem true that which isn't true. Isn't that your mission, gentlemen: to give life to fantastic characters on the stage?

CUE *The Manager:* ... proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards.

THE FATHER *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The ACTORS look at one another in amazement.]*

CUE *The Manager*: But what do you mean? Before, you said...

THE FATHER. No, excuse me, I meant it for you, sir, who were crying out that you had no time to lose with madmen, while no one better than yourself knows that nature uses the instrument of human fantasy to pursue her high creative purpose.

CUE *The Manager*: Very well, — but where does all this take us?

THE FATHER. Nowhere! It is merely to show you that one is born to life in many forms, in many shapes, as tree, or as stone, as water, as butterfly, or as woman. So one may also be born a character in a play.

CUE *The Manager*: So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! *[MANAGER and ACTORS burst out laughing.]*

CUE *The Father*: Exactly, and alive as you see!

THE FATHER *[hurt]*. I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

CUE *The Manager*: ... Out, please! Clear out of here! For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

THE FATHER *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: ... allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway.

THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the PROMPTER's box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however.

THE FATHER. Yes, that is the word! *[To Manager.]* The author who created us alive no longer wished, or was no longer able, to put us into a work of art. That was a real crime, sir. He who is born a character can laugh even at death. The writer dies; the creation does not — and it needs no extraordinary gift to live forever. Who was Sancho Panza? Who was Madame Bovary? They live eternally, because they found a fantasy that could nourish them. We had no such fortune.

CUE *The Manager*: ... quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

THE FATHER. We want to live.

CUE *The Manager*: For Eternity?

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

CUE *Player 3 (as Juvenile Lead)*: I've no objection, as far as that one is concerned!

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. *[To the MANAGER.]* But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon concert it among ourselves.

CUE *The Manager*: ... against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

CUE *The Manager*: And where is the "book"?

THE FATHER. It is in us! [*The ACTORS laugh.*] The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for him.

THE FATHER [*angrily*]. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: She has more stage presence than the second act. I'll say that.

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

CUE *The Mother*: ... the name of these two little children, I beg you... Oh God!

THE FATHER [*coming forward to support her as do some of the ACTORS*]. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

CUE *The Manager*: Quick, a chair! Here!

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

CUE *The Mother*: No, no; stop it please!

THE FATHER [*raising her veil*]. Let them see you!

CUE *The Manager*: ... understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife?

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

CUE *The Manager*: But how can she be a widow if you are alive?

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

THE FATHER. He isn't here, you see, not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama — powerful sir, I assure you — lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

CUE *The Mother*: ... my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

CUE *The Son*: ... bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. [*To the MANAGER.*] He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

CUE *The Son*: Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

THE FATHER. Phrases! Isn't everyone consoled when faced with a trouble or fact he doesn't understand, by a word, some simple word, which tells us nothing and yet calms us?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Even remorse. Especially remorse.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No, that isn't true. I've done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.

CUE *The Manager*: I don't understand this at all.

THE FATHER *[he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble].* Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

THE FATHER. But don't you see that the whole trouble lies here. In words. *Words.* Each one of us has inside him a whole world of things — his own world. Some of those things are unspeakable. So we speak around them. And how can we ever understand each other, if I mean one thing by my words and you hear another? We think we understand. We never really do.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* But you drove me away.

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* ... had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.]* You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. *[Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? *[At this point the LEADING LADY who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the LEADING MAN flirting with the STEP-DAUGHTER, comes forward and says to the MANAGER.]*

| **CUE** *The Manager:* You must please explain yourself quite clearly.

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor man, a clerk, a secretary of mine, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* They understood each other, kindred souls in fact, without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* So he thought of it — for them!

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. Things had reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes. I could see them silently asking each other how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And this alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage — to exasperate me beyond measure.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* Ah yes...

THE FATHER *[suddenly turning to the MOTHER].* It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

| **CUE** *The Mother:* He took my son away from me first of all.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* As one can see.

THE FATHER *[quickly]*. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. That, sir, was the reason I married her. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

CUE *Player 1:* These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

THE FATHER *[a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself]*. Fool! That is the proof that I am a man. This seeming contradiction, gentlemen, is the strongest proof that I stand here a *live* man before you. It is precisely this incongruity in my nature that has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* any longer; not so much for the boredom she inspired in me, as for the pity I felt for her.

CUE *The Mother:* And so he turned me out —.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

CUE *The Mother:* And to free himself.

THE FATHER. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. *[Beat.]* But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir. I did it for her sake more than for mine — I have never once doubted it. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* Did I ever lose sight of you, until that other man carried you off to another town? Out of pure interest in you, with no base motive in it, I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... come out. He came, sir, to see how I was growing up.

THE FATHER. This is infamous, shameful!

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* No. Why?

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. This boy here *[Indicating the Son.]* was educated away from home; when he came back, he seemed to me to be no more mine. With no mother between him and me, he grew up apart, on his own, with no tie of intellect or affection. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

CUE *The Son:* Literature. Literature.

THE FATHER. Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

CUE *The Manager:* It may be, but it won't act.

THE FATHER. I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She *[Pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER.]*, as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* and the skirt down past the knee!

THE FATHER. The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* As soon as my father died...

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. [*A small pointing gesture toward the MOTHER, immediately regretted.*] She can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him?

THE FATHER. That is exactly your mistake, never to have guessed any of my sentiments.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* After so many years apart, and all that had happened...

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them — and, [*the word arrives before he can stop it*] naturally, my interest dwindled. [*The room hears the word "naturally". He does not look up.*] But the drama culminated, unforeseen, on their return — when I was driven by the loneliness that still had its grip on me. Ah, what wretchedness is in the man who is alone, and too proud for the shabby, easy comforts. Not old enough to do without company. Not young enough to seek it without shame. It is worse than misery. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. [*A beat. He has to swallow.*] One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us. That's all.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* All appear to have the courage to do them though.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. But he is like all the others — he only admits, with the light of intelligence, the plain shame in all of us that most men prefer to close their eyes upon. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have.*

| **CUE** *The Manager:* Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Almost in time.

THE FATHER [*crying out*]. No — in time. *In time.* Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

THE FATHER. For the drama lies all in this — in the conscience that I have, that each one of us has. We believe this conscience to be a single thing; but it is many-sided. So we have the illusion of being one person for all, of having a personality that is unique in all our acts. But it isn't true. We perceive this when, tragically perhaps, in something we do, we are caught up, suspended on a kind of hook. Then we see that all of us was not in that act, and that it would be an atrocious injustice to judge us by that action alone — as if all our existence were summed up in that one deed. Now do you understand the perfidy of this girl? *She* surprised me in a place where she ought not to have known me — and now seeks to attach to me a reality I could never have supposed

I would have to assume, in a shameful and fleeting moment of my life. *[He is sweating through this speech. He has not noticed.]*

CUE *The Son:* Leave me alone. I don't come into this.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

CUE *The Son:* ... one suppose he must give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

CUE *The Son:* ... am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

CUE *The Son:* ... I am like? When did you ever bother your head about me?

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... *[Pointing out the MOTHER to the MANAGER.]* See, she's crying!

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* Like a fool.

THE FATHER *[indicating Step-Daughter].* She can't stand him, you know. *[Then referring again to the Son.]* He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. Possibly his situation is the most painful of all. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. *[In confidence.]* The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

CUE *The Manager:* ... out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

THE FATHER. He disappears soon, you know. And the baby too. She is the first to vanish from the scene. The drama consists finally in this: when that mother re-enters my house, her family — born outside of it and superimposed on the original — ends with the loss of the little girl, the tragedy of the boy, and the flight of the elder daughter. It cannot go on, because it is foreign to its surroundings. So we three remain — I, the mother, that son — and find ourselves strange to one another. We live in an atmosphere of cold desolation — the revenge, as he *[Indicating the Son.]* scornfully said, of this damned experimenting of mine. When faith is lacking, it becomes impossible to create certain states of happiness.

PART III *The Bargain*

12 SPEECHES · 179 WORDS

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* When you've got a character like me.

THE FATHER *[shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the MANAGER].* You be quiet!

CUE *The Manager:* It's new... hem... yes...

THE FATHER. Absolutely new!

CUE *The Manager:* ... must say, to come here and fling it at me like this...

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

CUE *The Manager:* ... Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

THE FATHER. No. I say born for the stage, because...

CUE *The Manager*: Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

THE FATHER. No sir, no. We act that rôle for which we have been cast, that rôle which we are given in life. And in my own case, passion itself, as usually happens, becomes a trifle theatrical when it is exalted.

CUE *The Manager*: ... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author.

CUE *The Manager*: I? What are you talking about?

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

CUE *The Manager*: Because I have never been an author: that's why.

THE FATHER. Then why not turn author now? Everybody does it. You don't want any special qualities. Your task is made much easier by the fact that we are all here alive before you...

CUE *The Manager*: It won't do.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

CUE *The Manager*: Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

CUE *The Manager*: ... a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

CUE *The Manager*: ... Who knows if we don't get something really extraordinary out of it?

THE FATHER. There's no doubt about it. They [*Indicating the CHARACTERS.*] had better come with us too, hadn't they?

Act Two

PART I *Backstage*

25 SPEECHES · 456 WORDS

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... have shot one of those two — or both. Father and son.

THE FATHER. Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

CUE *The Manager:* That'll do fine.

THE FATHER. A mirror.

CUE *The Manager:* ... try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

THE FATHER [*as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage*]. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

CUE *The Manager:* A rehearsal for them.

THE FATHER. But since we are the characters...

CUE *The Manager:* ... characters are there, in the "book" — when there is a "book"!

THE FATHER. I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

CUE *The Manager:* ... this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

THE FATHER. As we are...

CUE *The Manager:* ... cast themselves. You play the Mother. We must find her a name.

THE FATHER. Amalia, sir.

CUE *The Manager:* ... your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

THE FATHER. Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... [*Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the SECOND LADY LEAD.*] I see this woman here [*Means the MOTHER.*] as Amalia. But do as you like. [*Gets more and more confused.*] I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

THE FATHER. True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

CUE *The Manager:* ... the spirit of the piece is in you? Nothing of the kind!

THE FATHER. What, haven't we our own temperaments, our own souls?

CUE *The Manager:* ... the merit of it, believe me, will be due to my actors.

THE FATHER. I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

CUE *The Manager:* Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up...

THE FATHER. Maybe. But the voice, the gestures...

CUE *The Manager*: ... exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

THE FATHER. I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: By me, if you've no objection.

THE FATHER [*with a small bow toward Player 1*]. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: ... "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

THE FATHER. The performance he will give, even doing his best with make-up to look like me...

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: It will certainly be a bit difficult!

THE FATHER. Exactly! It will be difficult to act me as I really am. The effect will be more — apart from the make-up — how he supposes I am, how he senses me — if he senses me at all — and not how I, inside myself, feel myself to be. So it seems to me that anyone whose job it becomes to criticise us should take this into account...

CUE *The Manager*: ... here? You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

THE FATHER. Yes.

CUE *Player 2 (as Property Man)*: An ordinary envelope?

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

CUE *The Manager*: ... lady with Madame Pace: Oh! And this Madame Pace, where is she?

THE FATHER. She isn't with us, sir.

CUE *The Manager*: Then what the devil's to be done?

THE FATHER. But she is alive too.

CUE *The Manager*: Yes, but where is she?

THE FATHER. One minute. Let me speak! [*Turning to the ACTRESSES.*] If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

CUE *The Manager*: What are you going to do with the ladies' hats?

THE FATHER. Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

THE FATHER. To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

THE FATHER. Exactly; just like that, on show.

CUE *The Manager*: May we know why?

THE FATHER. I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? [*Inviting the ACTORS to look towards the exit at back of stage.*] Look! Look!

PART II *The Apparition*

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: There she is! There she is!

THE FATHER [*radiant*]. It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

CUE *Player 2 (as Leading Lady)*: A vulgar trick. And not even a good one.

THE FATHER [*dominating the protests*]. Excuse me, all of you! Why are you so anxious to destroy, in the name of a vulgar, commonplace sense of truth, this reality which comes to birth, attracted and formed by the magic of the stage itself — which has indeed more right to live here than you, since it is much truer than you, if you don't mind my saying so? Which is the actress among you who is to play Madame Pace? Well, here is Madame Pace herself. You'll allow, I fancy, that the actress who acts her will be less true than this woman, who is herself in person.

But the scene between the STEP-DAUGHTER and MADAME PACE has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of THE FATHER. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by THE FATHER, turn round and see MADAME PACE, who has placed one hand under the STEP-DAUGHTER's chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.

CUE *The Manager*: What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now?

THE FATHER. No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. [*Moves away.*]

CUE *The Mother*: ... town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

THE FATHER [*going to her also, at the same time, the body now beginning to give him away too*]. Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

THE FATHER [*to MANAGER*]. They can't be here together. And here's why: that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

The FATHER does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The ACTORS watch intently.

CUE *The Manager*: Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

THE FATHER [*coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was, that man did not show what he was feeling*]. Good afternoon, Miss.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: Good afternoon!

THE FATHER [*looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure*]. Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: No sir.

THE FATHER. You've been here before, eh? [*Then seeing her nod agreement.*] More than once? [*Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.*] Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

CUE *The Mother*: Oh, my God. My God.

THE FATHER *[playing his part with a touch of gallantry]*. Give it to me! I'll put it down. *[Takes hat from her hands.]* But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: No thank you, sir.

THE FATHER. Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: No, no! I couldn't wear it!

THE FATHER. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... because I am — as you see — you might have noticed.

THE FATHER *[a beat — the smallest pause. He did not, in fact, say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said something else. The audience must see the lie being made in real time.]*. ... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

PART III *The Substitution*

12 SPEECHES · 157 WORDS

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: Good afternoon, Miss...

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

A short, theatrical pause. The FATHER turns his face away. The STEP-DAUGHTER is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

CUE *The Manager*: You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

THE FATHER *[endeavouring to intervene]*. Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

CUE *The Manager*: Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

THE FATHER. Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

CUE *The Manager*: Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

THE FATHER. No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

CUE *The Manager*: ... should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

THE FATHER. Just so: actors! They act our parts exceedingly well — but it produces quite a different effect on us. They want to be us, and they aren't.

CUE *The Manager*: What is it, then?

THE FATHER. Something that is... that is theirs — and no longer ours...

| **CUE** *The Manager:* But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

THE FATHER. Yes, I understand... I understand...

| **CUE** *The Mother:* ... And she has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment. She [*Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.*] is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* ... the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise.

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

THE FATHER [*going towards him excitedly*]. Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

| *At the reiterated cry of THE MANAGER, THE MACHINIST lets the curtain down, leaving THE MANAGER and THE FATHER in front of it before the footlights.*

Act Three

PART I *The Argument over Reality*

16 SPEECHES · 523 WORDS

CUE *Player 2 (as Leading Lady):* ... to know which room we are in. They aren't going to guess.

THE FATHER *[the word lands physically — he turns too quickly].* The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *il-lusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

CUE *The Manager:* And why, if you please?

THE FATHER. It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

CUE *The Manager:* The illusion of a reality.

THE FATHER *[recovering, voice softer].* I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

CUE *Player 2 (as Leading Lady):* A game? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

THE FATHER. I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

CUE *The Manager:* Precisely —!

THE FATHER. Now, if you consider the fact that we *[Indicates himself and the other five CHARACTERS.]*, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

CUE *The Manager:* And what does that mean?

THE FATHER *[after watching them for a moment with a wan smile].* As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. *[Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the MANAGER and adds.]* But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. *[Looks the MANAGER in the eyes. Then, slowly, turns out toward the house. A pause long enough to feel.]* Can you tell me who you are?

CUE *The Manager:* What? Who am I? I am myself.

THE FATHER. And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because *you* and *I*...

CUE *The Manager:* I should say you were mad —!

THE FATHER. You're quite right to laugh. We are all making believe here. So you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there *[Indicates the LEADING MAN.]* to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see. *[Quiet.]* You see — I've caught you in a *trap*. *[The ACTORS laugh — too loudly, too quickly.]*

CUE *The Manager:* ... had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

THE FATHER. No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art *[Looking at the LEADING LADY as if anticipating her.]* which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. *[Beat.]* *Who are you?*

CUE *The Manager:* ... who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

THE FATHER *[with dignity, but not offended]*. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

CUE *The Manager*: ... asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

THE FATHER. But only to know if you, as you really are now, still see yourself as you once were — with all the illusions that were yours then. Think of those illusions, that mean nothing to you now, that don't even seem to you to exist any more. Don't you feel the very earth under your feet sinking, when you reflect that this *you* of today is fated to seem a mere illusion to you tomorrow?

A silence. The FATHER does not answer. He has, for once, no answer. The face changes before the body does. When he speaks again, the argument is no longer clean.

CUE *The Manager*: Well, well. And where does all this take us anyway?

THE FATHER. Oh, nowhere. Only to show you: if we *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* have no reality beyond the illusion, you mustn't count too much on yours either — like yesterday's, it may be an illusion to you tomorrow.

CUE *The Manager*: ... brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

THE FATHER *[the greatest seriousness — no smile]*. But of course. Without doubt.

CUE *The Manager*: Ah, really?

THE FATHER. Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

CUE *The Manager*: More real than I?

THE FATHER. If your reality can change from one day to another...

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

THE FATHER *[the cry breaks; afterward the body goes still — not the composure he had at the start of this part, but a different stillness, as if he has just walked into the wall of his own argument she has just shown him]*. No, sir. Not ours. Look here — that is the very difference. Our reality doesn't change. It *cannot* change. It cannot be other than what it is. Because it is already fixed. Forever. *[Quieter, the horror finding him.]* It's terrible. Ours is an *immutable reality*. Which should make you shudder when you approach us — if you are really conscious that your reality is a mere transitory and fleeting illusion, taking this form today and that tomorrow, according to your will. Illusions of reality. Represented in this fatuous comedy of life. That never ends. Nor can ever end.

PART II *The Refusal*

15 SPEECHES · 536 WORDS

CUE *The Manager*: ... did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

THE FATHER. It is the simple truth, sir.

CUE *The Manager*: ... is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

THE FATHER. I don't know to what author you may be alluding, but believe me, I feel what I think; and I seem to be philosophising only for those who do not think what they feel, because they blind themselves with their own sentiment. I know that for many, this self-blinding seems much more "human"; but the contrary is true. For man never reasons so much, and becomes so introspective, as when he suffers — since he is anxious

to get at the cause of his sufferings, to learn who has produced them, and whether it is just that he should have to bear them. The animals suffer without reasoning. But take a man who suffers and begins to reason about it — oh no, it can't be allowed. Let him suffer like an animal, and then — ah yes, he is "human"!

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

THE FATHER. I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

THE FATHER. Because I suffer, sir! I'm not philosophizing: I'm crying aloud the reason of my sufferings.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

THE FATHER. You have never met such a case, sir, because authors, as a rule, hide the labour of their creations. When the characters are really alive before their author, he does nothing but follow them — he has to will them the way they will themselves. When a character is born, he acquires at once such an independence, even of his own author, that everyone can imagine him in situations the author never dreamed of.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: Yes, yes, I know this.

THE FATHER. So what is there to wonder at in us? To be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him — answer me if these characters left alive, and yet without life, weren't right to do what they are doing now, after trying everything to persuade him to give them their stage life. We've all tried him in turn — I, she [*Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.*] and she. [*Indicating the MOTHER.*]

| **CUE** *Player 2*: I had no idea Pirandello was so chatty.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

| **CUE** *The Son*: Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

THE FATHER. Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... over the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

THE FATHER [*genuinely surprised, almost wounded*]. I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

THE FATHER. Well — if you take away from me the possibility of representing the torment of my spirit, which never gives me peace, you will be suppressing me. That's all. A man worth the name does not just live; he gives his own life a meaning. For me, this is everything. I cannot give it up — just to represent a mere fact, as she [*Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.*] wants. It's all very well for her. But I am not going to do it. It destroys my *raison d'être*.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

THE FATHER. Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

| **CUE** *The Manager*: ... your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

THE FATHER. All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

| **CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene in the garden with his mother.

| **CUE** *The Son:* ... go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

THE FATHER [*to MANAGER excitedly*]. You can force him, sir.

| **CUE** *The Son:* Nobody can force me.

THE FATHER. I can.

PART III *The Fountain*

6 SPEECHES · 67 WORDS

| **CUE** *The Son:* ... It throws our likeness back at us — with a horrible grimace.

THE FATHER. That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

| **CUE** *The Mother:* ... find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here.

THE FATHER [*going to SON in a great rage*]. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

| **CUE** *The Son:* I do nothing.

THE FATHER [*taking hold of him and shaking him*]. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

| **CUE** *The Mother:* Please! please!

THE FATHER [*not leaving hold of the SON*]. You've got to obey, do you hear?

| **CUE** *The Son:* There in the fountain...

THE FATHER [*pointing with tender pity to the MOTHER*]. She was following him at the moment...

| **CUE** *The Other Players:* No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

THE FATHER [*with a terrible cry*]. Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!